

Subject: Fwd: Town meeting communication channel issues
From: Stephen Harrington <stephenharrington@yahoo.com>
Date: 9/11/26, 10:55
To: Stephen Harrington <sth.alist@gmail.com>

Begin forwarded message:

From: Stephen Harrington <stephenharrington@yahoo.com>
Date: July 27, 2026 at 9:19:17 PM EDT
To: sbadmin@town.arlington.ma.us
Cc: jhurd@town.arlington.ma.us, jfeeney@town.arlington.ma.us
Subject: Town meeting communication channel issues

please, include the Letter below as correspondence received for the next board meeting and disseminate to Board members.

Stephen Harrington
Columbia Rd
Arlington

My name is Stephen Harrington. I live at 74 Columbia Road in Arlington.

First I thank Chief Flaherty for her common sense solution to the cemetery parking issue with residents and visitors parking overnight and contractors blocking grave site access. Her professionalism and de-escalation of the issue is a lesson for all of us.

Tonight, I am asking the Town to stop requiring resident advocacy to pass through insider permission before elected Town Meeting Members can reliably receive it and that such advocacy enters into the public record as Correspondence Received alongside other related documents.

Since COVID, Arlington Town Meeting has relied heavily on electronic communication. That changed the practical meaning of resident petition rights. In the old physical Town Meeting environment, residents could leave advocacy on the chairs of each member petitioning representatives directly in writing. Today, leaving advocacy on "the chairs" is banned and the meaningful channel became the Town Meeting Email List and related Town-controlled systems.

The general public does not have direct access to that channel. Residents must find a Town Meeting Member or official willing to submit or co-sign their advocacy. Materials are subject to Moderator review for “scope,” “appropriateness,” and civility. The fallback — emailing Town Meeting Members individually — is unreliable, vulnerable to blocking, spam filtering, missing addresses, and private social pressure while removing the advocacy from the public record.

This is not equal access. It is institutional gatekeeping.

I have overwhelming documentation of this problem. I will mention only three examples tonight, time permitting.

This concern became sharper when the Moderator administered a civility oath and stated that he would hold members to its spirit and values whether or not they took the oath. Civility may be a personal virtue, but as a government standard it becomes dangerous when paired with discretionary control over resident speech. TMMs have been warned by the Moderator using civility as a filter on speech directed at town officials outside of Town Meeting.

I gave the Town frequent offramps; all ignored.

In 2026, I demanded a neutral, unblockable, Town-administered resident communication channel that becomes part of the public record. Correspondence Received.

That remains my request.

I am asking for two things: first, that this issue be placed on a public agenda for discussion and action; second, that the Town Manager provide a written response addressing the Town’s authority over the TMM Email List, the basis for excluding direct resident submissions, and the process for adopting a neutral resident submission channel that becomes part of the public record.

The Town may not reject resident advocacy based on viewpoint, criticism of officials, tone, subjective civility, or undefined appropriateness. The issue is whether Arlington may design a Town-controlled communication system where residents need insider permission before elected representatives can reliably access germane advocacy.

I ask this Board to fix that system.

Examples:

In 2022, with Article 38, I tried to send advocacy to Town Meeting under the new process that required a Town Meeting Member co-signer. That intermediary became a gatekeeper, under social and political pressure, with concerns about being held

accountable for my words.

In 2024, with Article 14, the Moderator acknowledged the material was applicable to the article, but refused to "co-sign" for electronic distribution.

In 2024, with Article 56, I submitted technical, article-specific financial advocacy. Again, access to the official Town Meeting channel was denied because I was a resident rather than an approved insider.